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Editorial

Why African Nexus Quarterly?

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ABSTRACT

This founding editorial articulates the rationale, mission, and editorial philosophy of African Nexus Quarterly. Drawing on bibliometric, institutional, and epistemological evidence, it argues that the underrepresentation of Africa in globally indexed scholarship reflects structural inequalities in research funding, journal infrastructure, and skilled-labour mobility rather than a deficit of intellectual capacity. The editorial identifies three interconnected problems—chronic R&D underfunding, brain drain, and the coloniality of dominant knowledge frameworks—and positions the journal as an institutionally independent, open-access platform committed to Africa-centred, peer-reviewed scholarship that is simultaneously rigorous and policy-relevant.

KEYWORDS

*Africa-centred
knowledge production;
epistemic justice;
research
infrastructure;
scholarly publishing;
brain drain*

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Introduction

Every journal begins with a wager. The wager behind *African Nexus Quarterly* is at once modest and immodest: that an Africa-centred editorial lens -institutionally anchored in Türkiye yet oriented, without apology, toward the intellectual priorities of the continent -can make a measurable difference to how knowledge about Africa is produced, validated, indexed, and circulated. This first issue is not simply a collection of manuscripts. It is a declaration of intent, and it obliges me to explain, as plainly as an editor can, why this space is needed and what we intend to do with it.

The Structural Problem We Inherit

Let me begin where any honest account must begin: with data.

Africa accounts for roughly 17 percent of the world's population, yet its share of globally indexed research output has historically hovered between one and three percent of all publications recorded in Scopus or the Web of Science (Tijssen, 2007; Pouris & Ho, 2014). That figure has grown in absolute terms over the past two decades -meaningfully so- but it remains disproportionate in every sense that matters (Boshoff, 2010). A WHO-affiliated bibliometric review noted that Africa's share of global publication output rose from approximately 1.5 percent in 2005 to 3.2 percent by 2016, real progress accompanied, however, by a persistent relative marginalisation within high-impact, discipline-defining outlets (Adams et al., 2010).

The roots of this imbalance are structural and well-documented. The UNESCO Institute for Statistics reports that Sub-Saharan Africa's gross domestic expenditure on research and development (GERD) averaged approximately 0.32 percent of GDP in 2020-far below the world average of roughly 1.93 percent and far below the one-percent threshold that the African Union's own Agenda 2063 sets as a minimum target for member states (UNESCO Institute for Statistics [UIS], 2022; African Union Commission, 2015). Inadequate R&D investment directly constrains the size and continuity of the scholarly workforce: fewer full-time researchers, fewer functioning laboratories, fewer postgraduate programmes operating at the scale and quality required to sustain competitive publication pipelines (Mouton & Waast, 2009).

Low investment intersects, moreover, with structural disadvantages in scholarly infrastructure. Only a fraction of active African journals are indexed in Scopus or the Web of Science, which means that research published locally -often the most policy-relevant, the most contextually precise- disappears from the metrics by which global impact is measured (Alonso-Álvarez, 2024). This creates a vicious cycle: because African scholarship is underrepresented in the indices that govern hiring, tenure,

and grant allocation, African scholars face institutional incentives to publish in overseas outlets whose agenda-setting priorities may not reflect continental needs. The journal ecosystem that ought to sustain local academic communities is thereby systematically starved of its most productive contributors.

These are not grievances; they are empirical conditions. Recognising them is the precondition for addressing them.

The Mobility Problem and the Missing Connective Tissue

Compounding the capacity deficit is the well-known but persistently underanalysed phenomenon of skilled emigration. OECD data indicate that tertiary-educated individuals from Sub-Saharan Africa have among the highest probabilities of emigration to OECD countries of any region in the world; some national emigration rates for the highly skilled reach or exceed thirty percent (OECD, 2017). The continent loses an estimated 70,000 skilled professionals annually, with cumulative economic costs running into billions of dollars in foregone human capital (Docquier & Rapoport, 2012). The consequences for the scholarly community are especially acute: the scholars best equipped to anchor Africa-focused research programmes, those with doctoral credentials, international networks, and methodological breadth, are precisely those most likely to build careers abroad.

This is not a problem of individual disloyalty. It is a rational response to a global academic labour market structured to reward retention in high-income contexts and to penalise return. As the OECD's own analysis makes clear, the pull of established research infrastructures, stable funding environments, and internationally legible publication venues is powerful, and it operates most strongly on those who have already demonstrated the capacity to succeed within them (OECD, 2023). What results is a paradox: the diaspora scholars most capable of bridging African scholarly communities with global networks often lack institutionalised pathways to do so. Their expertise circulates internationally but rarely flows back, in peer-reviewed, policy-connectable form, to the communities whose challenges originally motivated their research.

African Nexus Quarterly is founded, in part, as a response to this structural absence. We intend to function as connective tissue -a platform that keeps Africa-based scholars in productive dialogue with Africa-oriented diaspora researchers, without requiring either group to abandon their institutional moorings or to re-enter the extractive dynamics that currently characterise so much North-South academic collaboration.

The Epistemological Stakes

The structural argument matters, but it is insufficient on its own. A journal can correct an indexing gap while leaving the deeper problem untouched. The deeper problem is what Sabelo J. Ndlovu-Gatsheni (2018) calls the "epistemic line": the systematic exclusion of non-Western ways of knowing from the domain of legitimate, internationally recognised knowledge. Mahmood Mamdani (2007) has made a complementary argument: that the conceptual vocabularies imported into African social science -state, citizenship, civil society, development- carry the sediment of colonial political categories and routinely generate analytical distortions when applied to contexts whose histories they were never designed to illuminate.

To be clear: we are not anti-Western, and we are not anti-empiricist. We do not subscribe to the view that methodological rigour is a Eurocentric imposition. What we do subscribe to is the proposition -now supported by a substantial body of postcolonial and decolonial scholarship- that the questions asked, the data collected, the theoretical frameworks applied, and the policy conclusions drawn are all shaped by the institutional contexts in which scholars work and the funding structures that sustain them (Connell, 2020; Quijano, 2000). When the overwhelming majority of knowledge about Africa is produced under Northern institutional conditions, validated by Northern peer-review panels, and circulated through Northern publication channels, the result is a systematic tendency -not a conspiracy, but a tendency -toward problem framings that privilege external intervention over local agency, crisis narratives over developmental complexity, and exceptional cases over structural patterns.

African Nexus Quarterly aims to cultivate a different default. Our editorial priorities will consistently favour scholarship that places African scholars, African institutions, and African policy communities at the centre of its analytical gaze, not as objects of external scrutiny, but as intellectual subjects generating knowledge that is rigorous, generalisable, and consequential far beyond the continent's borders.

The Unlikely Editorial Address

A word about our institutional location, which some readers will find surprising. This journal is hosted in Türkiye. That geographic position, which might seem to distance us from our subject matter, is in fact one of the conditions of our possibility.

Türkiye occupies a distinctive position in the contemporary global order: a middle-income country with a rapidly expanding higher education system, a growing tradition of South-South scholarly engagement, and no colonial history on the African continent. That absence matters. We are not

unencumbered by geopolitics -no journal is- but we are free from the specific entanglements that complicate Africa-focused scholarship produced within former colonial metropolises. We believe that an editorially autonomous, Africa-centred journal, supported by Turkish academic infrastructure, can offer a form of institutional independence that is genuinely rare in this field.

At the same time, we are acutely aware that "*Africa-centred*" cannot mean "*Africa-only*." The structural asymmetries we have described above are global in their architecture. Addressing them requires scholarship that speaks to, and is legible within, international academic conversations. We will therefore hold ourselves to the highest standards of peer review and methodological transparency, not as a concession to Northern gatekeepers, but because rigour is the currency of credibility and credibility is what this project needs to survive.

What We Will Publish, and What We Will Not

African Nexus Quarterly is a multidisciplinary, open-access journal. We will consider original research articles, review essays, policy analyses, methodological discussions, and critical commentaries from across the social sciences, humanities, and interdisciplinary fields, provided that the work engages substantively with African contexts, actors, or questions. We do not restrict submissions to Africa-based authors; diaspora scholars, international collaborators, and scholars whose primary affiliation is outside the continent are warmly welcomed, provided the intellectual centre of gravity remains firmly on the continent.

We will not publish work that treats Africa as a laboratory for testing theories developed elsewhere without critically examining that theoretical transfer. We will not publish work whose empirical claims rest solely on secondary sources accessible from abroad, when primary engagement with African communities, archives, and institutions is feasible and ethically appropriate. And we will not allow the geography of authorship to substitute for quality: a manuscript from a scholar based in Nairobi or Lagos or Dakar will be held to exactly the same standards as one from a scholar based in London or New York, no lower, and no higher.

Our double-blind peer-review process will draw on a genuinely global, Africa-weighted pool of reviewers. We are committed to turnaround times that respect authors' time, and we are committed to feedback that is developmental rather than merely evaluative, recognising that early-career scholars working in resource-constrained environments may need more substantive editorial engagement to reach their potential.

An Honest Accounting of What We Do Not Yet Know

It would be dishonest to close this editorial without acknowledging the uncertainties that accompany a first issue. We do not yet know whether we will secure the indexing that will make this journal visible to the widest possible audience. We do not yet know whether our model -open-access, South-based, editorially independent- will prove financially sustainable over the long term. We do not yet know whether the scholars we most wish to serve will find in our pages a home worth publishing in.

What we do know is that the need is real, the structural conditions are precisely as we have described them, and the intellectual ambition that animates this project is shared by a remarkable community of scholars across the continent and its diaspora.

Yet, our ambition extends beyond merely adding another title to the directories of academic publications. We expect our readers not only to consume these pages but to contest them, to build upon them, and to use them to dismantle and rebuild the conceptual architectures of their respective fields. Our hope is that *African Nexus Quarterly* will serve as a sanctuary for intellectual risk-taking—a site where theories are not merely imported and applied, but refashioned and born anew from the ground up. Ultimately, our success will not be measured by metrics or database indexing alone, but by the extent to which we help expand the boundaries of what is deemed thinkable and legitimate in African studies.

This first issue is the beginning of a conversation. We invite you—readers, reviewers, authors, and critics—not simply to observe this project, but to co-author its future.

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Note on Access and Submissions: In alignment with our commitment to removing structural barriers to knowledge, African Nexus Quarterly is a fully open-access journal published on a quarterly schedule. All content is freely available under a Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 (CC BY 4.0) licence, and submissions are accepted on a rolling basis through our online manuscript portal.

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